

NOTHING BEATS A HEALTHY HEARTBEAT

DR ARUN MOHANTY
Senior Consultant Cardiologist
Sir Gangaram Hospital, New Delhi

The young and the restless today are bent on establishing their norms of being the generation who want to live in the moment, who want to hustle, and at the same time make the most out of their lifespan. One thing that has become a new and ever-increasing source of health crisis among the previously young and healthy is their overburdened and unhealthy hearts. The heart has been roman-ticised innumerably through culture and fiction. When taken care of well, it also enables a healthy lifespan. On the occasion of National Doctor's Day, thus, it becomes imperative to discuss the heart and the matters of a healthy heart at that. What does it take to have a healthy and beautifully func-tioning heart? How aware are the young of the repercussions of their lifestyles on this precious or-gan called the heart? The answer to these questions paves the way for understanding the risk factors that are contributing to the ever-increasing heart attacks in the age group of young adults.

Once seen as a problem affecting mostly the elderly has now become a rising concern for the younger generation. And with every passing year, this problem is increasing with the rising percent-age of young people getting heart problems. One of the most vital organs and a centre of the circula-tory system, the Heart is an organ without which the body means nothing. Medical experts have no-ticed and recorded an alarming increase in the cardiovascular problems suffered by the young adult generation. Cardiac arrest, heart attack, and other cardiovascular diseases (CVDs) have been a mat-ter of global concern but the recent reports of young adults being diagnosed with these problems are especially concerning for countries like India. Coronary heart disease is a condition when there is a blockage in heart muscles and the blood flow through the arteries is suddenly stopped leading to a chronic heart condition. In worse cases it can lead to a fatal heart attack. Many young celebrities in the last couple of years have passed away due to heart-related problems. Sudden deaths of young and 'fit' actors like Siddharth Shukla, Puneeth Rajkumar, Raj Kaushal, and Amit Mistry have shak-en the nation and finally brought much-needed attention to the increasing cases of heart problems in the younger generation.

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Factors responsible for CVDs

Certain primary factors identified by the medical fraternity include less physical activity, increased use of alcohol, smoking, obesity etc. which put pressure on the cardiovascular system. The system is compromised due to poor lifestyle choices made these days in terms of mental and physical health. The dependence on white food like refined sugar, refined flour, white rice, salt, and potato has in-creased the risk of metabolic syndromes. Easy access and over-exposure to ultra-processed foods though cheaper in cost have a heavy price on health.

Sedentary lifestyle, stress, and dietary issues have proved to be a great contributing factor to devel-oping a heart condition and ignoring the symptoms on regular days increases the chances of a seri-ous heart condition. And especially after the Pandemic, be it dealing with financial or personal loss-es or new desk-bound jobs, people have become more vulnerable to many such health issues. With work-from-home culture kicking in and becoming a norm, lifestyle choices contribute to the proba-bility of people suffering from a heart condition. Increased screen time and available food delivery agents are causing unhealthy and uncontrolled BMIs.

What can be done?

The medical fraternity has time and again emphasised the benefits of good lifestyle practices. Keep-ing a check on one's dietary habits lowers the risk of heart problems as one becomes better equipped to curb any cardiovascular conditions. The significance of making right nutritional choices and fol-lowing self-care routines cannot be overstated. Mental health needs to be prioritised and spending time with family, meditation and yoga help in managing stress in times when the competitive young people are anxious about excelling in every sphere of life. Regular physical activity for at least 30-40 minutes like walking, cycling, running and swimming are good for the heart. Avoiding smoking, and alcohol use, and eliminating sugar and processed food from daily routine would certainly make a positive difference. Also, it is important to have regular health check-ups to keep an eye on any red flags or any potential risk factors especially if there is any chance of an underlying genetic heart condition. The focus on nutrients like Vitamin D, proteins, Omega 3, and Omega 6 would help make the right decisions for a balanced diet.

Awareness is the Key

The patients are their families should educate themselves on the many advanced technologies avail-able in the present day and age for superior cardiac care. For instance the stent deployment done under the guidance of Intravascular Ultrasound (IVUS), has better possibility of optimal result even in the most complex cases and better patient outcome. High-definition intravascular ultrasound helps us to see a coronary artery from the inside-out. This unique HD view provides us with critical clinical information that is not possible with routine imaging methods, such as coronary angi-ography, performed in the cath lab, or even non-invasive CT scans. Basic awareness of these tech-nologies would help the patients and their families in making well informed decisions when present-ed with the treatment options.